

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

HHS UAC Program — Care Load & Placement Demand Forecasting

Prepared for Government Program Stakeholders · September 2026

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Purpose

This summary translates a detailed forecasting analysis of the HHS Unaccompanied Alien Children (UAC) Program into plain-language findings and recommended actions for program planners. It draws on 1,061 days of daily program records (January 2023 – December 2025) and a comparison of seven forecasting methods, presented in full in the accompanying research paper and live dashboard.

At a Glance

PROGRAM SCALE CHANGE ↓ 71% Avg. daily care load, 2023 → 2025	SHARPEST DROP Q4 2024 – Q2 2025 Daily intake fell over 90% in this window
BEST FORECAST MODEL Random Forest 99.8% accuracy in recent stable conditions	FORECAST CONFIDENCE Reliable ≤ 30 days Wider margin of error beyond 30 days

Key Findings

- 1. **The program has fundamentally shrunk in scale, not just fluctuated.** Average daily care load fell from about 8,700 children in 2023 to about 2,500 in 2025 — roughly a two-thirds reduction. Most of this change happened quickly, within a six-month window (late 2024 into mid-2025), not gradually across all three years.
- 2. **Intake (transfers into care) led the decline, not discharges.** Daily transfers into HHS care fell more than 90% in the same window that care load itself dropped. This means transfers-in is an early signal worth watching closely — it moved before the overall care-load numbers did.
- 3. **The forecasting model is highly accurate right now — because conditions are currently very stable.** Our best model (Random Forest) correctly predicts near-term care load with about 99.8% accuracy. This strong result reflects the fact that daily numbers have been unusually steady over the past several months; accuracy has not yet been tested during a period of rapid change like the one seen in 2025, and should be re-checked if conditions shift again.
- 4. **Forecasts are trustworthy in the near term, less so far out.** Predictions for the next 1–30 days are well-supported by the data. Predictions beyond 30 days should be treated as a general direction, not a precise number — our testing found that real-world uncertainty grows faster the further out you look than a simple rule-of-thumb would suggest.

- **5. Weekly and seasonal patterns exist but are secondary.** There is a modest, regular weekly pattern (slightly higher mid-week) and a modest seasonal pattern (higher in December–January), but both are small compared to the scale of the 2025 program change described above.

What This Means for Planning

Capacity plans, staffing models, and budget assumptions that were set using 2023–2024 figures are very likely out of date. The program today is operating at roughly one-third the average daily volume it saw two years ago. Planning figures should be reset against recent conditions (the last 3–6 months), not the multi-year historical average, which now significantly overstates typical current volume.

Why the Near-Term Accuracy Figures Come With a Caveat

Our forecasting model looks very accurate right now (about 99.8%) because the last several months have been calm and steady — a model that expects "tomorrow to look like today" naturally scores well under calm conditions.

That accuracy figure has not yet been proven during a fast-changing period like the one the program experienced in early-to-mid 2025. Decision-makers should treat current high-accuracy figures as a best case, and build in extra caution if conditions start shifting again.

Recommended Actions

Immediate (Next 30 Days)

- Reset shelter capacity thresholds using the last 3–6 months of data, not the 3-year historical average, which currently overstates expected volume by roughly 2–3×.
- Use forecasts confidently for near-term (1–30 day) staffing and placement planning; treat forecasts beyond 30 days as directional guidance only.

Near-Term (Next Quarter)

- Track daily transfers into HHS care as a leading indicator — it moved before overall care load did in the 2024–2025 shift, and would likely do so again in any future change.
- Re-run this forecasting analysis on a recurring basis (e.g., quarterly) rather than treating current figures as permanent, given how quickly conditions changed in 2025.

Ongoing

- Pair every forecast figure with its confidence/reliability context — a single accuracy percentage, without the caveat above, can be misleading to planners unfamiliar with how it was measured.
- If program volume begins changing again, treat the current forecasting model's outputs with added caution until it has been re-validated under the new conditions.

Full Documentation

This summary accompanies two more detailed deliverables prepared as part of this analysis: a full research paper (methodology, exploratory data analysis, complete model comparison, and limitations) and a live, interactive Streamlit dashboard covering forecasting, discharge demand, model comparison, early-warning alerts, and forecast-uncertainty visualization across five modules.

